

Chapter 33 Part 1

——Sister, will you be afraid?

——I'm not afraid, because I believe there are gods watching.

——Sister, you don't need to be afraid either. You're so cute and beautiful, the gods will protect you from the shadows.

"But sister, there are no gods in this world."

——There are, as long as we believe, they will exist.

"Sister, does it hurt?"

——It doesn't hurt, don't be afraid.

"Sister, please don't smile anymore, okay? They'll hit you."

——No, only when I smile will the gods see me.

——I believe life will definitely get better, because we will surely have lots of love.

——So I must smile, smile happily, smile freely, so the gods can see.

Distant conversations were forcibly dragged out from the depths of memory, and Xu Qingzhu's mind was like towering waves being stirred up.

The bedroom was terrifyingly quiet, with only Liang Shi's even breathing as she lay sleeping on the bed. The perfectly curved smile at the corner of her mouth instantly pulled Xu Qingzhu back to the spring of eighteen years ago.

That year, on her way home from school, she was dragged into a black car by some people who covered her eyes with black cloth strips.

The run-down van reeked of unpleasant odors. The vehicle constantly bumped and swayed, cotton strips were stuffed in her mouth, her teeth ached, her mouth hurt, and her tears soaked her clothes.

She was taken to a dilapidated chemical factory in the suburbs—rusty iron gates, windowless rooms that never saw daylight, and two vicious yellow dogs that barked incessantly.

The lights in the chemical factory were dim and yellow. A group of people gathered around a small table playing poker and drinking, speaking in a dialect she couldn't understand, laughing and cursing. In this large room, there were seven or eight little girls about her age. The one beside her wore a blue dress and had fair, tender skin.

While she was still at the age of losing baby teeth, that little girl already had a full set of neat, white teeth.

The little girl especially loved to smile. When she smiled, her eyes curved into crescents, and every time she smiled, the curve of her mouth was exactly the same, looking very healing.

This was Xu Qingzhu's first time experiencing such a thing. She was terrified and had been crying since being tied up and brought in. Her tears fell like broken pearls, and she cried until her eyes started to hurt. The little girl next to her handed her a lollipop and whispered, "Sister, don't cry anymore. We'll get out soon."

The little girl said, "My name is Liang Shi¹. The 'liang' from 'pillar,' the 'shi' from 'suitable.' What about you?"

"My name is Xu Qingzhu."

"How old are you?"

"Five years old."

"I'm seven, so I'm older than you, which means I'll protect you."

"These people are after money. Once our moms and dads give them the money, they'll let us go," little Liang Shi said.

They stayed in that windowless room for a long time, eating the same food as the two yellow dogs every day.

Liang Shi kept saying someone would come to rescue them.

But one day, when Liang Shi was asleep, one of the kidnappers said, "The Liang family is so rich, yet they won't even pay five million to ransom their daughter. They even told us to get rid of her."

Xu Qingzhu kept hesitating about whether to tell Liang Shi about this, but she woke up shortly after the kidnapper said it.

With red eyes, she told Xu Qingzhu, "They're all lying. My mom and dad will definitely come save me."

Footnotes: ¹ Liang Shi: 梁适 - The name uses characters meaning "pillar/beam" and "suitable/appropriate"